

audience all day long, and you can audition at night or during your long summer holidays.

Your education can be the best investment you'll ever make, or the worst one. It's an expensive and time-consuming undertaking. And make no mistake—it is an investment. It's not a break between childhood and adulthood, or an opportunity to take it easy before real life kicks in. Every dollar you spend on postsecondary education has to be viewed in terms of its financial return. Getting smart costs money, so don't be a dummy.

Money Mistake: You Bought Fancy Wheels to Match Your Fancy Education

THE FIX: TWO WHEELS GOOD, FOUR BAD

You don't need a car when you're a student. Plain and simple. You need time to study. So you had a car in high school? Great—sell it and give your Secret 10 a nice boost. “But Uncle Kevin,” you say. “I have to commute to college.” Fine. That's what public transit is for: for reading textbooks! A young person who owns a car and has a student loan is setting him- or herself up for financial ruin. Between insurance, gas, parking, and repairs, you are bleeding money. If commuting is a problem, live closer to campus. Get a bunch of roommates and rent a house. Find a part-time job near the school. Saving money should be as important as your grades right now. Don't like my advice? Then you won't like this either: Get a bike. It's cheaper than public transit.

Strictly from a financial point of view, cars are ridiculous money pits (more on that in Chapter 13). Pollution and global warming aside, as gas prices go up and up, a car is becoming more and more of a luxury product rather than a given. But North America has a love affair with the car. According to the most recent numbers out of the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics and Consumer Spending, people spend more money keeping their cars on the road than they do putting food on the table. Even the venerable *Wall Street Journal*, in the middle of